

 EDITORIAL STYLE GUIDE

# One publication. Four series. Thirty episodes, locked.

This is the canonical reference — every post is built against it. The design language does not change for at least the first 30 episodes. People follow consistency, not creativity: anyone seeing a single slide, even a cropped screenshot six months from now, should instantly think **"That's Startup Sutra."**

## 01 Positioning

StartupSutra is a **media brand**, not a meme page. Format: visual case studies about business decision-making, published daily at 8 PM. The company featured is always the **evidence**; the subject is the **decision**.

### The Substitution Test — our editorial signature

**"If I replace the company's name with another company, does the lesson still hold?"**

- **Yes** → evergreen. Ship it.
- **No** → it's a history lesson. Rework it until the lesson stands alone.

Practical consequence: argument-driven structure over chronology. Open with the claim, prove it with the company, end with a question the reader must answer about **their own product**.

**The mantra: the company featured is always the evidence; the subject is the decision.**

We're not documenting history. We're extracting decisions.

## 02 The four series

Each pillar is a branded, color-coded, independently numbered series.

| SERIES                                                                                                       | ACCENT / DEEP     | SUBJECT                           | EXAMPLE SUBJECTS                         |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
|  <b>CASE STUDY</b>          | #f59e0b / #ea580c | How a decision created success    | Instagram, Airbnb, Netflix, Canva        |
|  <b>STARTUP FAILURE</b>     | #ef4444 / #b91c1c | How a decision destroyed value    | BlackBerry, Kodak, Nokia, WeWork         |
|  <b>MARKETING BREAKDOWN</b> | #3b82f6 / #1d4ed8 | Why a marketing move worked       | Apple, Nike, Duolingo, Red Bull          |
|  <b>FOUNDER FRAMEWORK</b>   | #22c55e / #15803d | A mental model founders can apply | First Principles, Flywheel, JTBD, Pareto |

### Series color drives

- Kicker pill + headline accent words
- Quote-card border and tint
- Active progress dot, swipe cue
- Ambient glow, highlight cards

### Master brand stays amber — always

- The S logo mark
- "Sutra" in the wordmark
- The follow-card S mark
- On every series, no exceptions

### Episode numbering

- Numbered **per series** — Case Study #001 ≠ Startup Failure #001.
- **Category large, number subtle.** The cover kicker shows the series name only; the number lives small in the top-right corner as #NNN · slide/07.
- The last slide teases continuity ("New episode tomorrow") without hard-coding the next series.

### Published register

-  CASE STUDY #001 — Instagram (2026-07-19)
-  STARTUP FAILURE #001 — BlackBerry (2026-07-20)

## 03 Visual system

- **Canvas:** carousel 1080×1350 (4:5), 7 slides · reels 1080×1920 (9:16), 30fps
- **Background:** near-black navy #0b0e14 ; ambient glow in series color; faint 90px grid, masked radially
- **Text:** primary #f4f1ea · dimmed #8b93a3 · secondary #aab2c0 · footer #525a68
- **Typography:** Inter only — 900 headlines (−1.5px tracking), 800 quote cards, 700 UI, 600 body. Emoji: Noto Color Emoji.
- **Header:** S mark + wordmark left · #NNN · slide/07 right. **Footer:** dots · @StartupSutra · SWIPE →

## 04 Visual hierarchy rules

1. One idea per slide. The surprising element gets the biggest type.
2. Contrast carries meaning: winner bright, loser dimmed — the design argues before the copy does.
3. The screenshot slide (the lesson) is the most minimal slide of the set.
4. **Never:** stock photos, illustrations, AI imagery, gradients beyond the accent. Emojis only as functional icons.

## 05 Writing voice

- Short declarative sentences. One thought per line.
- Conversational verbs — "deleted", not "deprecated"; "loved", not "adopted".
- Numbers over adjectives — "1 million users in 2 months", never "huge growth".
- Second person for lessons: turn the insight toward the reader's product.
- No jargon, no hashtag stuffing, no exclamation marks. Confidence is quiet.

### Hook formulas (cover slide / reel opening)

| FORMULA              | PATTERN                             | EXAMPLE                                       |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Reversal</b>      | "X didn't lose to Y. It lost to Z." | BlackBerry (SF #001)                          |
| <b>Sacrilege</b>     | Destroy something sacred            | "Imagine deleting 80% of your startup."       |
| <b>Near-miss</b>     | The success almost didn't happen    | "The billion-dollar app almost didn't exist." |
| <b>Hidden cause</b>  | "Everyone thinks Y. It was Z."      | —                                             |
| <b>Question trap</b> | A question with no easy answer      | "Why did the best product lose?"              |

A hook is never a summary. It creates a gap the carousel closes.

### 06 • Carousel structure (7 slides)

1. **Hook** — series + subject pills, claim, tension line
2. **Setup** — the world before; the company's bet
3. **Shift** — what changed
4. **Evidence** — the visual argument
5. **Mistake / Insight** — the decision, named
6. **Lesson** — screenshot slide, minimal
7. **CTA** — reader question + rows + follow + tease

### 07 • Reel Philosophy (25–30s max)

- The reel is **not** the carousel — a trailer, never a summary
- One idea only · no duplication of the lesson or evidence
- **Signature edit:** 0–3s challenge a belief (cold open) · 3–15s build tension · 15–22s one emotional line · 22–25s invite; CTA promises value
- Human, not AI — a founder's observation over coffee: calm, confident, curious; pauses are the delivery
- VO natural pace, cuts on breath boundaries; music in-app: minimal cinematic, investigative
- **Trailer Test:** can a viewer explain the carousel afterward? Yes → it gave too much

## 05A Human Voice Framework

### The Conversation Test

"Would I actually say this **in a conversation with a founder?**"

If the answer is no — rewrite it. This single rule removes 90% of AI-sounding copy.

#### ✗ Written, not spoken

*"BlackBerry failed because it underestimated the app ecosystem."*

#### ✓ Revealed, not presented

*"Here's the part most people miss. BlackBerry wasn't losing phones. It was losing relevance."*

**AI-tells to hunt down:** stacked abstractions · symmetrical sentence pairs that sound written · adjectives doing the work numbers should do · explaining when you could be revealing.

### The Screenshot Quote Test (hard rule) · The Unforgettable Line

Every episode must contain **one sentence people want to save** — it gets the most minimal slide and its own caption lines. **No sentence → the episode isn't finished.** And one step further: one line people **repeat months later** ("Apple changed the question. BlackBerry kept answering the old one."). Draft three candidates in Phase 2; the best earns a slide punchline. Explaining informs; **revealing gets quoted.**

## 07A Narration Rules (delivery)

The guide defines writing; this defines **delivery**. They are different.

- Write for speech, not reading. Maximum 8–10 words per sentence.
- Pause after every important line. One idea = one breath. Intrigue before explanation.
- Never sound like you're presenting. Sound like you're **revealing** something.
- Script format: one line per breath; ellipses mark pauses; every reel scene cut lands on a breath boundary.

## 11A Editorial Review — the pre-publish gate

Every episode is scored on the **finished slides** before publishing. Below target on any metric → rewrite. Not because it's "bad" — because StartupSutra doesn't publish average episodes. Scores go in the episode README.

| METRIC       | QUESTION IT ANSWERS                          | TARGET |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------|--------|
| Scroll Stop  | Does slide 1 interrupt a thumb mid-scroll?   | 9/10   |
| Curiosity    | Does every slide make you need the next one? | 9/10   |
| Save Worthy  | Is there a sentence people will screenshot?  | 9/10   |
| Share Worthy | Would a founder send this to a co-founder?   | 8/10   |
| Human Voice  | Does it pass the Conversation Test?          | 10/10  |

## 08 Caption style

1. Open by restating the hook in one line (not word-for-word).
2. 4–8 short lines building the argument — each stands alone.
3. The lesson, isolated on its own lines.
4. 💬 question → ❤️ save prompt (tie to a real work moment: "for your next roadmap discussion") → 📖 2–3 sources.
5. No hashtag walls. Reel captions are shorter and never duplicate the carousel's.

## 09 Alt text

Every slide gets alt text: `Slide N: [text on slide, condensed]`. Cover example: *"Slide 1: BlackBerry didn't lose to Apple. It lost to the future."* Literal first — screen readers before keywords.

## 10 Story templates (posting day)

| WHEN         | ASSET                   | ADD                                          |
|--------------|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 8 PM         | Cover slide             | "New episode" + series emoji + link sticker  |
| +2 hours     | Lesson slide            | Poll: "Have you seen this mistake up close?" |
| Next morning | Best comment screenshot | "Tell us yours 🙋"                            |

Stories reuse post assets only — never new designs.

## 11 CTA style

- One question per post, always about the reader, answerable in one line.
- Fixed rows: 🙋 Tell us below · ❤️ Save this post · 🔄 Share it with a founder.
- Follow card: "Follow @StartupSutra — daily startup case studies."
- Continuity tease on the last slide / end card; series-agnostic wording.

## 12 The five-phase production process

We are not making Instagram posts. We are **producing editorial episodes**. Every episode moves through five phases, in order:

### Phase 1 · Research

Facts · timeline · sources · competing viewpoints. If credible accounts disagree, know both sides before choosing the angle.

### Phase 2 · Editorial

Answered in writing before any design work: **What's the decision? What's the lesson? What's the screenshot quote?** Run the Substitution Test. No answers → no episode.

### Phase 3 · Writing

Carousel · caption · alt text · stories. Conversation Test line by line; hunt AI-tells. Render and review every slide at full size.

### Phase 4 · Performance

Reel script per Narration Rules — one line per breath, pauses marked. VO → silence-detect → cuts on breath boundaries → render → mux. Music in-app, 15–20% under VO.

### Phase 5 · Review

Conversation Test on finished slides → Editorial Scorecard → final approval. Below target → back to Phase 3. Record scores in the episode README. Post at 8 PM.

## 13 Editorial Philosophy — the DNA

| PRINCIPLE                         | WHAT IT MEANS                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 · Teach principles, not history | We don't publish because BlackBerry failed. We publish because founders can avoid making the same decision.                                      |
| 2 · Leave one question unanswered | If every question is answered inside the carousel, there's no discussion and no reason to comment. The Founder Question is real, not rhetorical. |
| 3 · Respect the reader            | Never over-dramatize. Never exaggerate. Never use clickbait the content can't justify. <b>Curiosity is earned, not manufactured.</b>             |

**Benchmark:** ● Startup Failure #001 — BlackBerry is the first episode produced under this system. Every future episode is compared against it.

**Consistency is the strategy. The guide is the brand.**